# Describing change: tenses, prepositions and trend language

## Understand it

Task 1 describes change. Choose the tense from the time on the chart: past years = past simple; up to now = present perfect; future predictions = will / is expected to / is projected to.

Two patterns make your writing varied: verb + adverb (rose sharply) and adjective + noun (a sharp rise). Use both, and always get the preposition right.

## The rules

- Past data: past simple. Sales rose in 2010. Use the past perfect only for an earlier past: By 2010, sales had doubled.
- Verbs of change: rise, increase, grow, fall, drop, decline, fluctuate, peak, level off, remain stable.
- Prepositions: rose TO 40% (the final figure), rose BY 10% (the size of change), FROM 20% TO 30%, at a peak OF, reached a low OF.
- Adjective + noun and adverb + verb: a sharp rise = rose sharply; a gradual fall = fell gradually.

## All the words and forms you need

| | |
|---|---|
| **Up** | rise · increase · grow · climb · go up · rocket · soar |
| **Down** | fall · decrease · decline · drop · go down · plummet · dip |
| **No change** | remain stable · stay constant · level off · plateau · stabilize |
| **Up and down** | fluctuate · vary · be volatile |
| **Highest / lowest** | peak at · reach a peak of · hit a low of · bottom out at |
| **Speed and size** | sharply · dramatically · steeply · significantly · steadily · gradually · slightly · marginally |
| **Prepositions** | to (final level) · by (amount of change) · from … to … · at (a point) · of (a peak of) · over (a period) |
| **Future** | is expected to · is projected to · is predicted to · will probably |

## Where you use it

**Writing:** The overview says the main trend; the detail paragraphs use exact figures with correct prepositions.

**Speaking:** Part 3: Prices have risen steadily over the last ten years.

**Reading:** Notice how trend verbs are paraphrased: rise = go up, increase = climb.

## More examples

- The number of cars rose steadily from 2000 to 2010.
- There was a sharp drop in sales in March.
- Prices peaked at $40 in 2015 before falling to $25.
- Unemployment has remained stable since 2018.
- Online shopping is projected to double by 2030.
- Coffee consumption fluctuated between 10 and 12 kilos per person.

## Common mistakes

| WRONG | RIGHT |
|---|---|
| ✗ Sales rose by 40% in 2010. | ✓ Sales rose to 40% in 2010. (if 40% is the final level) |
| ✗ The number is increased sharply. | ✓ The number increased sharply. |
| ✗ It had a sharply rise. | ✓ It had a sharp rise. |

## Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. How has your town changed in the last ten years?
2. Has the price of food gone up recently?
3. How will technology change in the next decade?
4. Which things are becoming more popular among young people?
5. Has the number of tourists in your country increased?

## Writing practice

Describe this data in 3 sentences: City population 2000: 1 million; 2010: 1.5 million; 2020: 1.5 million; 2030 (forecast): 2 million.

## Practice

1. Complete: Sales rose ___ 20% ___ 35%.

2. Complete: The price fell ___ 5 dollars.

3. Rewrite with an adverb: There was a gradual decline.

4. Rewrite with a noun: Exports rose sharply.

5. Correct: The figure was risen in 2012.

6. Choose: The rate (peak / peaked) at 12% in May.

## Answers

1. from; to
2. by
3. It declined gradually.
4. There was a sharp rise in exports.
5. The figure rose in 2012.
6. peaked